Two-mode Network Analysis of Culture Concepts

Draft

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Abstract

Kroeber and Kluckhohn's classic 1952 monograph *Culture: A Critical Review of Concepts and Definitions* brought together over a hundred scholarly definitions of culture and indexed the key concepts they discuss. We build two networks from that index to explore how concepts and works are connected. In the *definitions network*, concepts like "society" and "beliefs" are linked to 170 different scholars' definitions, grouped into seven categories but each credited to its own author. In the *works network*, the same concepts are linked to the books and papers cited in those definitions. By comparing both networks, we can see which concepts span many scholars' work and which are concentrated in particular sources. We present basic statistics about the networks, visualize the data using correspondence analysis and spanning trees, and highlight the key concepts and works that anchor each network.

1 Data and networks

We build two networks from K&K's Index B. The *definitions network* links 472 concepts—concrete ideas like "society," "customs," and "beliefs"—to 170 scholarly definitions of culture. Each definition carries the name of its author and falls into one of seven categories, which K&K label with the capital letters A through G: A Descriptive, B Historical, C Normative, D Psychological, E Structural, F Genetic, and G Incomplete. The *works network* links the same 472 concepts to 133 authored works (books and journal articles), so we can see which ideas appear in which scholarly sources. Both networks use the same set of concepts, which lets us compare how the definitions and works overlap in what they discuss. The definitions in the network come from K&K's own author index (167 sources) plus three additional attributions from the main text of their book (C-I-18a, D-II-16, E-17) but missing in the index. Concepts have consistent names across the networks; where a concept appears under different headings in K&K's source text, we treat it as a single concept. Works are named by their author(s) and year, and a single work can be cited under multiple definitions.

The definitions network naturally breaks into 11 separate components, with the largest containing 624 nodes. The works network has 10 components, with the largest containing 593 nodes. Our analysis focuses on these largest components, which contain virtually all the meaningful connections. We use maximum spanning trees across multiple projections to identify the strongest connections in different views of the network.

2 Overview of the networks

Table 1 gives summary statistics for both networks. The first three rows show node and edge counts. The "degree" rows counts connections of each node type; a concept's degree is how many

definitions (or works) mention it, while a definition's or work's degree is how many concepts it contains. In both networks, concepts and definitions differ substantially in their average degree.

Table 1: Summary statistics for the two networks. Average nearest-neighbor degree (k_{nn}) is the average degree of a node's neighbors; degree correlation shows how a node's degree relates to the degree of its neighbors.

	Definitions network	Works network
Concept nodes	472	472
Definitions / works	170 codes (5 isolated)	133 works (4 isolated)
Edges	1193	1165
Density	0.015	0.019
Mean degree, concepts	2.53 (range 1–36)	2.47 (range 0–33)
Mean degree, definitions/works	7.02 (range 0–25)	8.76 (range 0–51)
Mean k_{nn}, concepts	10.28	14.64
Mean k_{nn}, definitions/works	8.96	8.73
Degree correlation r	−0.096	−0.183

We see a notable pattern in the lower rows of the table documenting the degree correlation in each network; concepts with many connections tend to link to definitions or works with few, and vice versa. The nearest-neighbor rows show the other side of this pattern. A concept's neighbors average 10.3 (definitions network) or 14.6 (works network) uses, while a definition's or work's neighbors average only about 9 concepts, so concepts attach preferentially to heavily used nodes. The works network is also slightly denser (0.019 against 0.015) despite nearly identical edge counts, because it has fewer second-mode nodes. Finally, the maximum work degree of 51 belongs to Kelly & Kluckhohn 1945a, a fact that returns in the spanning-tree analysis below.

Figure 1 shows the degree distribution plots for each set of nodes in each network. Most concepts are lightly connected, with half appearing in only one or two definitions, and half being cited by only one or two works. In contrast, definitions and works are more heavily connected, wtih the average definition covering 7 concepts (median 7), and the average work covers 8 concepts (median 8), with some definitions and works discussing many more. This asymmetry means that a few concepts are discussed widely, while most concepts appear in just one or two places. The two second-mode distributions differ in their tails: works reach degree 51 while definitions top out at 25, so a single work can cover far more concepts than any single definition. The concept distributions, by contrast, are nearly identical across the two networks, as expected given that both share the same 472 concepts.

3 Maximum spanning trees

A maximum spanning tree (MST) keeps the strongest ties in a network while still connecting every node, using as few links as possible. A two-mode network has no ties between two concepts or between two definitions, so we analyze it through multiple one-mode projections [Everett and Borgatti, 2013]. Following Breiger [1974], two concepts are tied if they share at least one definition or work, with weight equal to the number they share. Likewise, two definitions (or works) are tied through the concepts they share. In matrix form, the projections are:

$$W_{\text{concept}} = AA^{\top}, \qquad W_{\text{def}} = A^{\top}A,$$

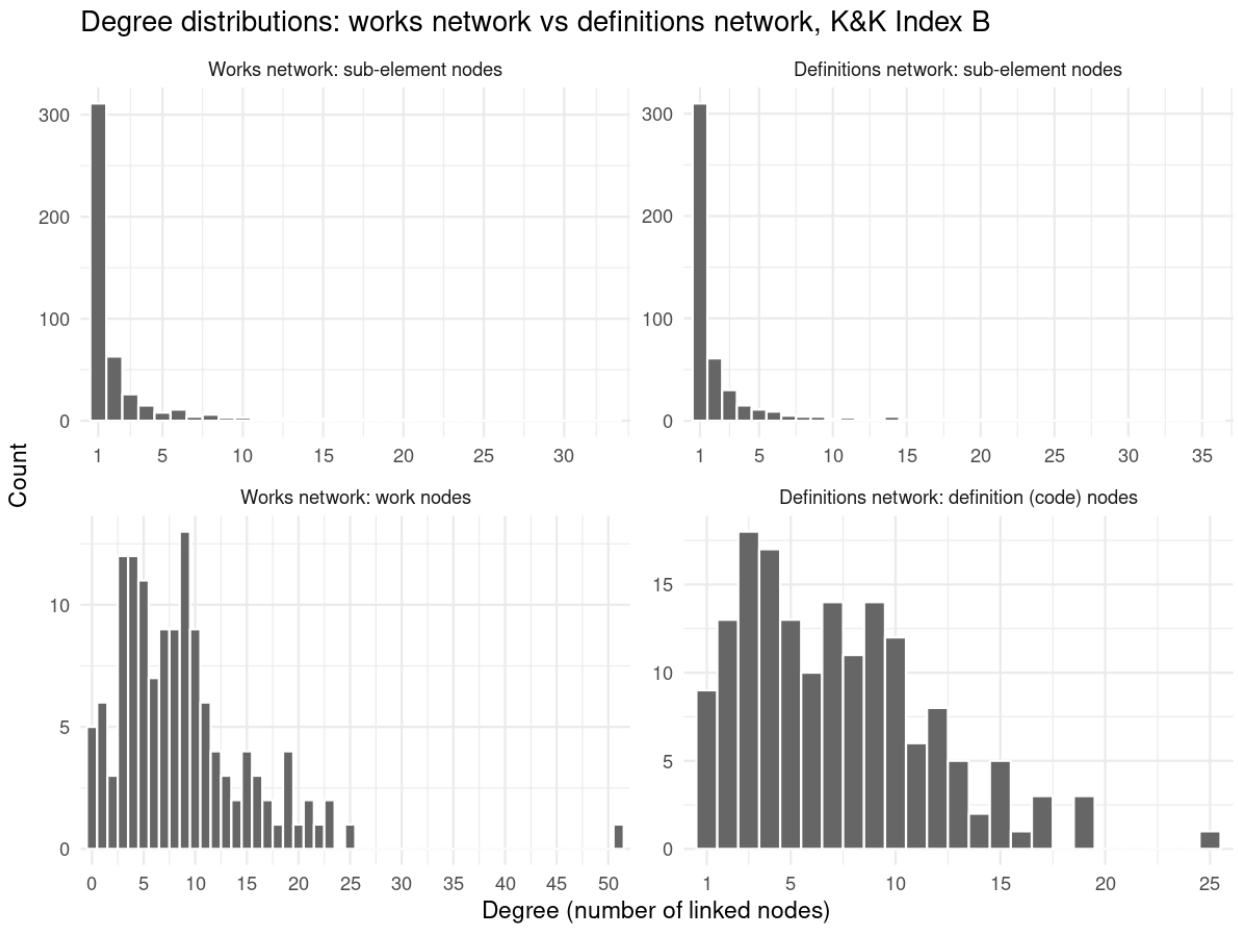


Figure 1: Degree distributions. Top row: sub-elements in the works network (left) and the definitions network (right). Bottom row: works (left) and definition codes (right).

where $(W_{\text{concept}})_{ij} = \sum_k a_{ik}a_{jk}$ counts the definitions that include both concepts i and j. Each projection is a weighted graph whose edges are the off-diagonal pairs with positive weight. We build projections from the 2-core of each network's largest component.

The maximum spanning tree of each projection is found by computing the minimum spanning tree on negated weights, $-w$. Kruskal [1956] sorts edges from largest weight to smallest and adds each unless it would close a cycle, producing a tree that maximizes $\sum_{e \in T} w_e$. Because the 2-core is connected, each tree has exactly $|V| - 1$ edges. In the visualizations, node size shows betweenness within the tree and node color shows the community structure detected using Newman's leading-eigenvector method applied to the tree.

The definitions network has two main projections. The concept-level tree (Figure 2) shows how 159 concepts cluster. The definition-level tree (Figure 3) shows how 145 definitions cluster. Table 2 lists the top 10 concepts and definitions by betweenness in their maximum spanning trees.

In the concept tree (Figure 2), the four largest nodes—social, group, society, and behavior—are exactly the top four of Table 2, and each anchors one of the tree's visible color regions. Social heads a green region of social-organizational vocabulary (social heritage, institutions, customs, social group), society anchors a pink region of learned and shared behavior (learned behavior, habits, socially transmitted), and behavior and group bridge the two. Beliefs and customs, fifth

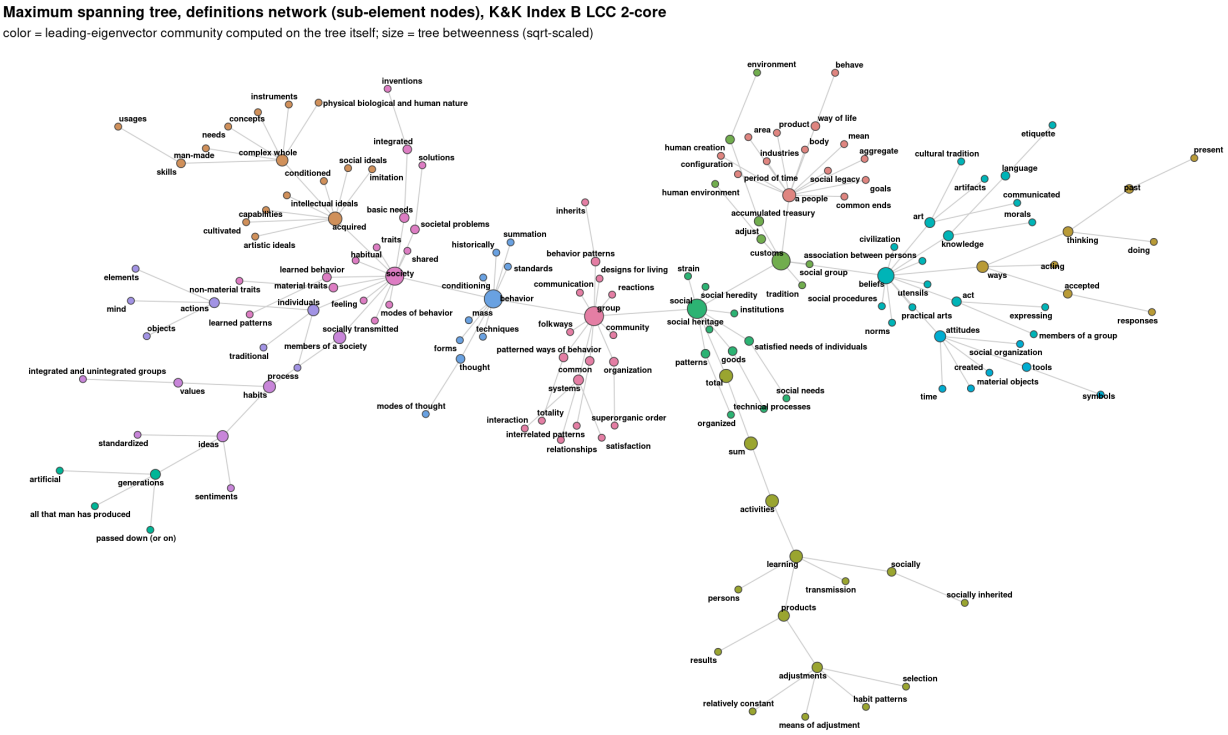


Figure 2: Maximum spanning tree of the definitions network, sub-element (concept) nodes. Color is the leading-eigenvector community on the tree; size is betweenness in the tree.

and sixth in the table, head the teal region of norms, knowledge, and artifacts. The tree also has one long peripheral branch running from total and sum down through activities, learning, transmission, products, and adjustments; this chain collects the acquisition vocabulary of the Genetic definitions and hangs off the core through a single path, so these ideas connect to the rest of the network only transitively.

The definition tree (Figure 3) puts its three largest nodes, F-I-3, C-I-6, and F-I-8, at the center of a single large community that mixes Normative (squares) and Genetic (pentagons) definitions, consistent with the table, where seven of the top ten definitions carry a C or F code. Degree and betweenness dissociate in this ranking: C-I-6 combines the second-highest betweenness with the highest tree degree (12), acting as the main hub of that community, while F-I-3 reaches the highest betweenness with only four ties, sitting on the paths that join the community to the rest of the tree. One author supplies a striking share of the bridges, as Bidney holds three of the ten most central definitions (C-II-3, C-II-4, and A-16). Away from the center, the Descriptive (A) definitions form a separate orange community in the upper left around A-3, and a chain of Descriptive and Historical definitions (A-16, C-I-4, A-1, A-14) runs along the right side, showing that the earliest and simplest definitions connect to the core through fewer, longer paths.

The works network also has two main projections. The concept-level tree (Figure 4) shows how 157 concepts cluster within the works network. The work-level tree (Figure 5) shows how 119 works connect through shared concepts. Table 3 lists the top 10 concepts and works by betweenness centrality.

The works-network concept tree (Figure 4) resembles its definitions-network counterpart but with a sharper hierarchy. Social is again the largest node, and here it sits at the junction of three large color regions, a green region of normative and symbolic vocabulary headed by customs

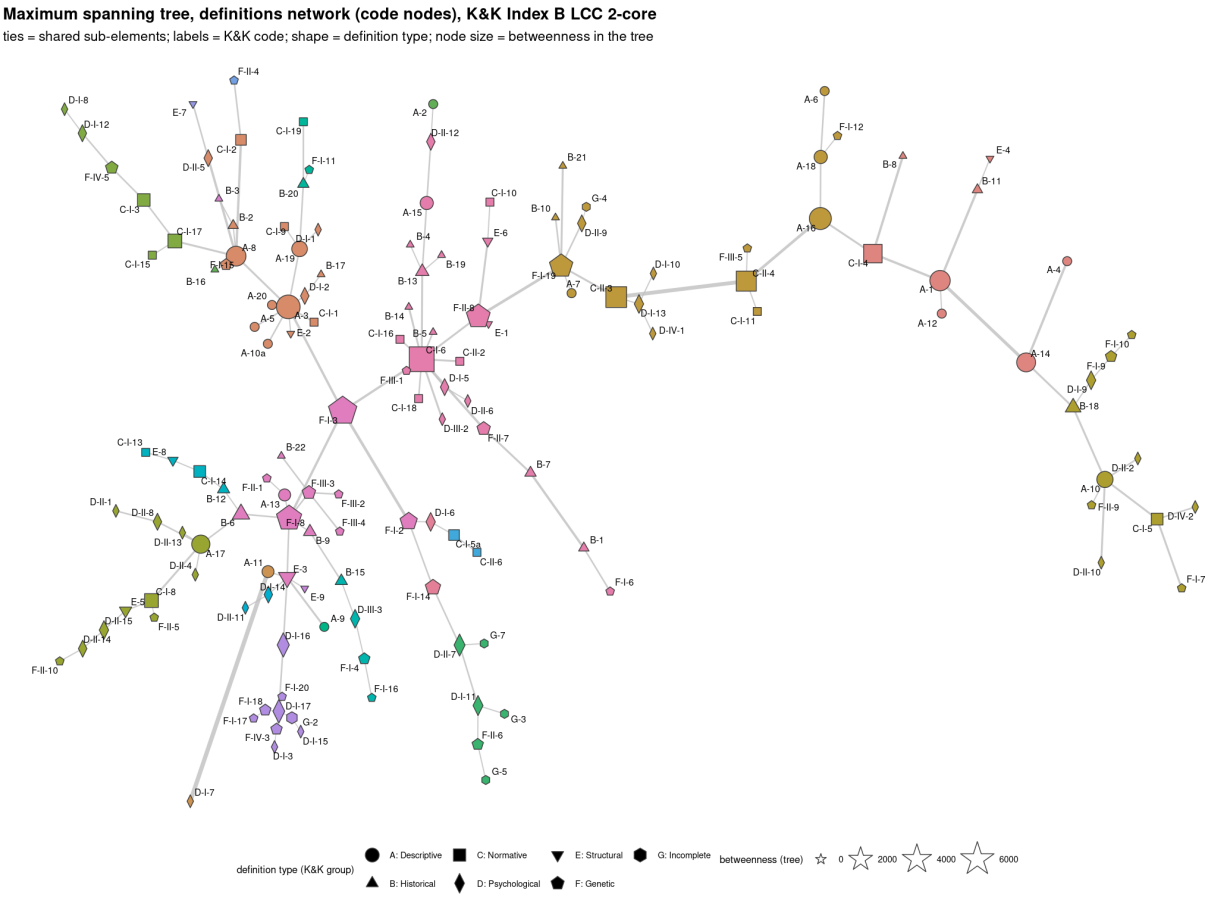


Figure 3: Maximum spanning tree of the definitions network, code (definition) nodes. Color is the leading-eigenvector community on the tree; size is betweenness in the tree.

(knowledge, beliefs, language, attitudes, symbols), a pink region of social organization around group, and a yellow region of behavior and acquisition (behavior, area, mass, transmission, habits). Society combines its high betweenness with the largest tree degree in the table (22), drawing many short spokes, while the acquisition chain seen in the definitions tree reappears at the top of the plot through members of a society, transmission, habits, and products.

The work tree (Figure 5) has a single dominant center. Kelly & Kluckhohn 1945a, the largest node and top entry of Table 3, sits at the middle of the plot with nineteen spokes reaching into every color region, so nearly any path between two works on opposite sides of the tree passes through it; it is at once the largest hub and the strongest bridge. Young 1934, Gillin 1942, Winston 1933, and Kroeber 1948a, the next four works in the table, appear as secondary hubs each heading their own community, and Linton appears twice in the top ten (1936 and 1945b), the only author with two such works. Most works, by contrast, are small peripheral leaves attached by a single edge, visible as the many small nodes at the plot's edges; Willey 1929, for example, despite its central position in the drawing, is one such leaf, a reminder that the spring layout places nodes by topology rather than importance.

Note to Table 2: Definition codes use the format X-Y-Z, where X is a letter (A–G) for K&K's seven definition categories (Descriptive, Historical, Normative, Psychological, Structural, Genetic, Incomplete), Y is a roman numeral for the subcategory, and Z is the number of the definition within it.

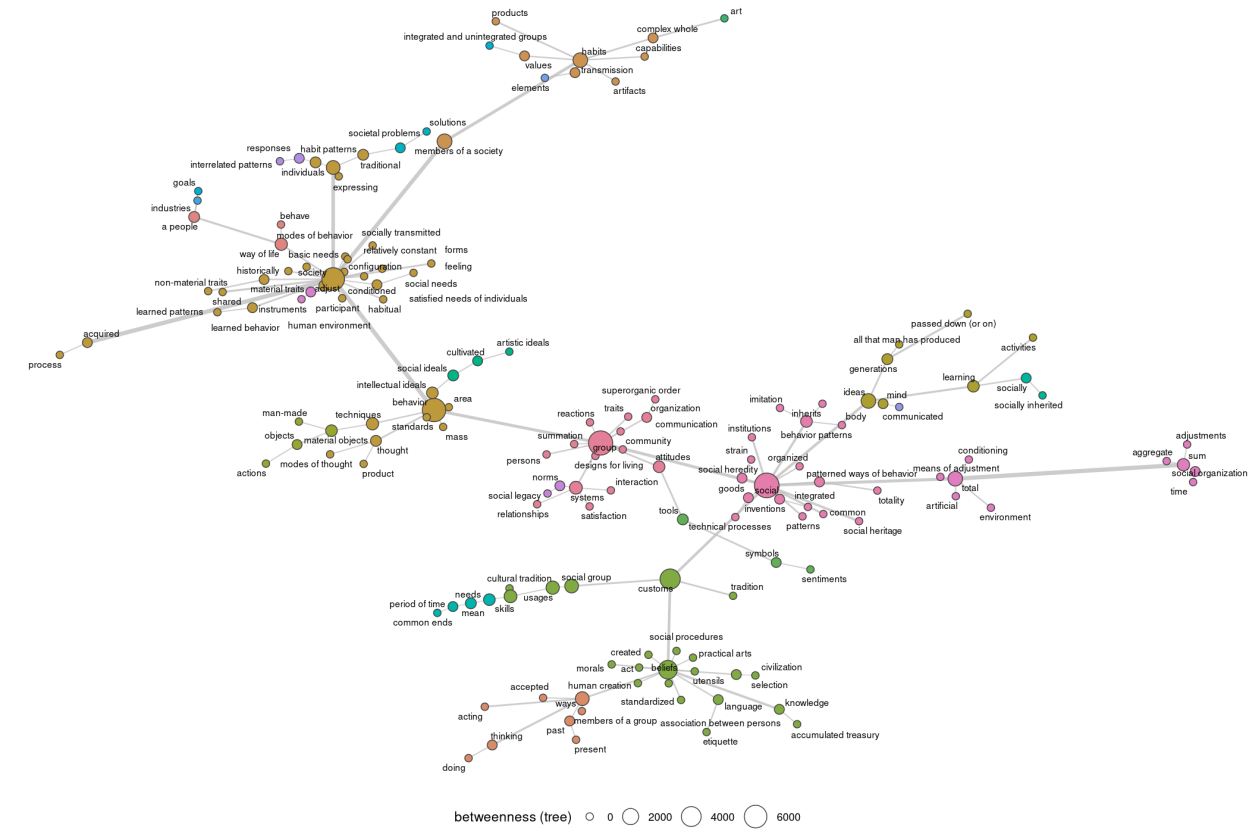


Figure 4: Maximum spanning tree of the works network, sub-element (concept) nodes. Ties count the works that cite both sub-elements.

Taken together, the four trees tell a consistent story. Eight of the ten most central concepts are the same in both networks—social, group, society, behavior, beliefs, customs, total, and members of a society—and each of the leading concepts anchors one of the color regions of the concept trees, so the conceptual core of the culture concept is stable whether it is measured on definitions or on the works that cite them (systems and sum enter the definitions ranking, ideas and generations the works ranking). The two networks differ in how concentrated their second mode is. Among definitions, centrality is spread fairly evenly: the top definition and the top concept reach almost identical normalized betweenness (69%), and no single definition approaches gatekeeper status. Among works, centrality concentrates at a single point, Kelly & Kluckhohn 1945a at 83% of the maximum possible, with the runner-up below 42%; the works literature is more star-shaped around one synthetic review than the definitions are around any of their members. In both concept trees the acquisition and transmission vocabulary sits on a single peripheral chain rather than at the core, suggesting that Genetic concerns, however common in the definitions themselves, connect to the rest of the conceptual structure only through a narrow path.



Figure 5: Maximum spanning tree of the works network, work nodes. Color is the leading-eigenvector community on the tree; size is betweenness in the tree.

4 Data-driven types: non-negative matrix factorization

The spanning trees and the community colors above classify nodes hard: each work belongs to exactly one community of the tree. Non-negative matrix factorization (NMF) [Lee and Seung, 2001] offers a soft, parts-based alternative. It approximates a non-negative matrix V by a product WH with all entries non-negative, so every node carries a loading on each factor and every factor is an additive mixture of the original features, with no subtractive terms. We run three NMF analyses on the works network: one on the coding structure, one on the wording of the definition statements, and one representing each work by the concatenated wording of the definitions its codes carry, and ask in each case how far the data-driven types agree with K&K's own seven categories A–G. All use the same base-R implementation (Euclidean multiplicative updates, deterministic given a seed, with ten random restarts per value of k), and all fix k at seven, one factor per K&K group. Fixing k this way is a choice, not a result: the reconstruction error falls monotonically in k without an elbow, and restart stability is flat beyond $k = 2$, so neither criterion selects a number of factors on its own.

Table 2: Top 10 nodes by Freeman-normalized betweenness in the definitions network MST.

Node type	Node	Norm. Betw. (%)	Degree
Concepts	social	69.11	16
	group	62.73	12
	society	49.06	14
	behavior	48.88	6
	customs	31.19	6
	total	18.76	3
	beliefs	17.89	6
	systems	14.51	6
	sum	12.01	3
	members of a society	10.88	3
Definitions	F-I-3	69.14	4
	C-I-6	57.54	12
	F-I-8	48.46	6
	F-II-8	40.84	4
	F-I-19	38.60	6
	A-3	34.04	9
	C-II-3	33.15	3
	C-II-4	29.35	4
	A-16	26.62	3
	C-I-4	22.19	3

4.1 Types from the coding structure

The first analysis factorizes the 156 × 118 sub-elements × works matrix of the works 2-core, the same matrix the work tree of Figure 5 was built from. Table 4 gives the top sub-elements of each of the seven factors, which we label as follows: a *way of life* factor (a people, way of life, group, behavior patterns), a *transmitted ideas* factor (ideas, generations, attitudes, what is passed down), a *society–individual behavior* factor (behavior, society, individuals), a *norms and knowledge* factor (beliefs, customs, knowledge, language, art, morals), an enumerative *complex whole* factor (sum, total, beliefs, activities, tools), a *social organization* factor (social, social heritage, institutions), and a *learning and acquisition* factor (members of a society, acquired, society, habits). Figure 6 shows each work's loadings, rescaled to sum to one per work, with works grouped by their dominant factor. The dominant-factor split of the 118 works is 12, 15, 23, 15, 12, 18, and 8; most works lean on one or two factors rather than one.

To compare these types with K&K's categories, each work inherits the group of its codes (the letter A–G of the codes it is cited under; a work's dominant group is its plurality letter). This label is well defined—the median work sits in a single group—so the comparison is not an artifact of works straddling categories. The agreement between the dominant factor and the dominant group is at the level of chance: adjusted Rand index 0.029 against a permutation baseline whose 95th percentile is 0.023, and no factor maps onto any group. The largest cell in the whole cross-tabulation is eight works.

4.2 A spanning tree of the factor types

The works factors can be hardened into a network the way the trees above were built. Binarizing the loadings at 0.10 turns each work into a member of the factors it loads on substantially: 17 of

Table 3: Top 10 nodes by Freeman-normalized betweenness in the works network MST.

Node type	Node	Norm. Betw. (%)	Degree
Concepts	social	73.18	15
	group	56.51	11
	behavior	50.04	6
	society	49.79	22
	beliefs	33.57	16
	customs	33.33	4
	ideas	19.09	4
	total	14.71	7
	generations	11.07	4
	members of a society	9.79	2
Works	Kelly & Kluckhohn 1945a	83.02	19
	Young 1934	41.78	7
	Gillin 1942	40.14	8
	Winston 1933	34.13	9
	Kroeber 1948a	31.58	5
	Folsom 1931	21.98	6
	Herskovits 1948	19.28	8
	Linton 1936	13.05	5
	Dixon 1928	11.42	4
	Linton 1945b	11.34	3

the 118 works belong to a single factor, 47 to two, 46 to three, and 8 to four, and no work drops out. Projecting the resulting works × factors biadjacency ties two works by the number of factors they share, giving 4,449 ties in a single component, and the maximum spanning tree of that projection (Figure 7) again has $|V| - 1$ edges. The threshold, like k, is a choice rather than a result: lower it and the projection densifies; raise it toward 0.3 and nearly two-thirds of the works fall back to a single factor, and one work drops out entirely.

The tree's bridges are not the concept tree's. Kelly & Kluckhohn 1945a, the dominant center of the concept-based work tree (Table 3), is a leaf here, tied to a single neighbor, and Winston 1933 and Kroeber 1948a, secondary hubs there, rank last and near-last of the 118 works. In the other direction, Boas 1930, the strongest bridge of the factor tree, is a leaf of the concept-based tree, and Osgood 1942 and Slotkin 1950, also central here, hold no short paths there; only Gillin 1942 and Linton 1945a are central in both. The two community partitions agree only weakly (adjusted Rand index 0.07), sixteen communities covering this tree against nineteen in the concept-based one. Neither tree is wrong: the two tie definitions ask different questions. A work is central in the concept tree when it draws on many distinct sub-elements that other works also draw on; it is central in the factor tree when its pattern of concept use sits between the factor profiles of other works. The inversion is itself evidence for the reading below—the position of a work in the corpus depends on what is counted as a tie, and no tie definition so far recovers K&K's groups.

4.3 Types from the wording of the definitions

The second analysis asks the same question of the definition texts themselves, independently of K&K's coding. The corpus holds 172 definition codes carrying a quotation: the Table 2 texts mapped to K&K codes through the crosswalk, the appendix-only texts, and five statements K&K print themselves. Documents average about thirty words, so the term–document matrix is built

Table 4: Top five sub-elements of each factor, works NMF at $k = 7$ (loadings normalized to unit sum).

Factor	1st	2nd	3rd	4th	5th	
F1	Way of life	a people	way of life	group	behavior patterns	transmission
F2	Transm. ideas	ideas	generations	attitudes	passed down (or on)	common
F3	Soc.–indiv. beh.	behavior	society	individuals	group	thought
F4	Norms, knowl.	beliefs	customs	knowledge	ways	language
F5	Complex whole	sum	total	beliefs	activities	tools
F6	Social org.	social	social heritage	customs	institutions	patterns
F7	Learning, acq.	members of a society	acquired	society	habits	complex whole

restrictively: tokens of three letters or more, a stopword list that removes the words nearly every definition contains (culture, society, social, man, and the general definitional vocabulary total, whole, learned, acquired), and terms kept to a document frequency between two documents and half the corpus, leaving 412 terms weighted by TF–IDF. The four quotations K&K and Boroch print in French or German enter as English translations (K&K's own rendering for Maquet, ours for the other three, verified against the printed originals). As with the coding structure, the factorization is run at $k = 7$, one factor per K&K group.

The factors again find recognizable themes rather than K&K's categories (Figure 8), and we label them by their leading terms: *mental and holistic* (concept, mean, holistic, mental), *thought and expression* (use, thoughts, think, express, words), *species and utensils* (species, events, order, utensils), *material vs. non-material* (material, non, traits, possesses), *passed down generations* (generation, sum, products, passed down), *symbolic systems* (process, concrete, symbolic, systems, cumulative), and *feelings and adjustment* (certain, inevitable, feeling, thinking). On a corpus this small a factor can be driven by one author's phrasing—the literal word "Kluckhohn" is among the top terms of the feelings-and-adjustment factor—so the labels should be read as descriptive of the top terms, not as clean concepts. Against the A–G groups the agreement is again chance-level (adjusted Rand index 0.026, permutation baseline 95th percentile 0.017), with no factor exceeding 53% purity in any group.

4.4 Pairwise agreement of the three classifications

A third analysis represents each work not by its coding and not by a single text but by the concatenated wording of all the definition statements its codes carry, factorized at the same $k = 7$ over the same 118 works of the 2-core. Its factors read as *goals and ways of living*, *passed down generations*, *material vs. non-material*, *symbolic systems*, *definitional formulas* (quotation boilerplate—*definition*, *said*, *according*—rather than a theme), *mental and holistic*, and *species and utensils*. Against the groups its agreement is chance-level as well (adjusted Rand index 0.010, permutation baseline 95th percentile 0.025), and it agrees hardly more with the coding-structure factors (adjusted Rand index 0.018): which sub-elements a work's definitions are filed under and how those definitions are worded are two cuts of the same works that share almost nothing.

Figure 9 compares the three classifications pairwise, one panel per pair. Every group's works scatter over all seven structural factors, and scatter as widely over the works-as-texts factors; the structural factors scatter over the works-as-texts factors in turn. The one visible partial agreement

is between the *transmitted ideas* and *passed down generations* factors, which exchange most of their works—the one place the two signals gesture at the same theme. The grey node collects the 15 works whose codes tie across two or three groups—Linton 1936, Sapir 1921, Kroeber 1948a, and the other synthetic treatments K&K cite for definitions straddling their own categories.

4.5 Interpretation

None of the three signals recovers K&K's taxonomy: not the works' pattern of concept use, not the wording of the definition statements, and not the two combined at the level of the work. Two readings are possible. One is that K&K's groups classify the emphases of individual *statements*, and that these emphases are lost when statements are aggregated to the works that contain them; against this stands the fact that works overwhelmingly sit within a single group, so the aggregation mixes little. The other, which we find more plausible, is that the seven groups are editorial categories—useful for organizing a bibliography—rather than dimensions along which the corpus varies. This is consistent with the spanning-tree picture above, where the vocabulary the Genetic group concerns itself with sits on a peripheral chain of the concept trees rather than forming a region of its own, and with the community structure of the trees, which follows concept vocabulary, not authorial schools. Hardening the works factors into a tree (Figure 7) does not change the verdict: its bridges are largely a different set of works, its communities do not follow A–G either, and the disagreement between the two tie definitions reinforces the point that no single structural reading of the corpus reproduces the taxonomy. The null result should be read against the method's limits as well: the number of factors was fixed to match the taxonomy under test rather than selected by the data, the short corpus makes TF–IDF factors fragile (restart agreement hovers near 0.5 at every $k \geq 3$), and the texts are K&K's own selections rather than the works' full statements.

5 Limitations

The networks depend on the K&K Index B transcription and on the verified-code filter. Element names are not unique across headings, so same-named elements are merged, which can join unrelated entries. Works are keyed by author and year, so a work with several year forms may appear twice. Several readings depend on OCR corrections recorded in the repository's manual-fix files; the validators check structure and round-trips, not the content of each edge. Three codes that are not in Index A (C-I-18a, D-II-16, E-17) are included from the main text; the basis for each is documented in the repository.

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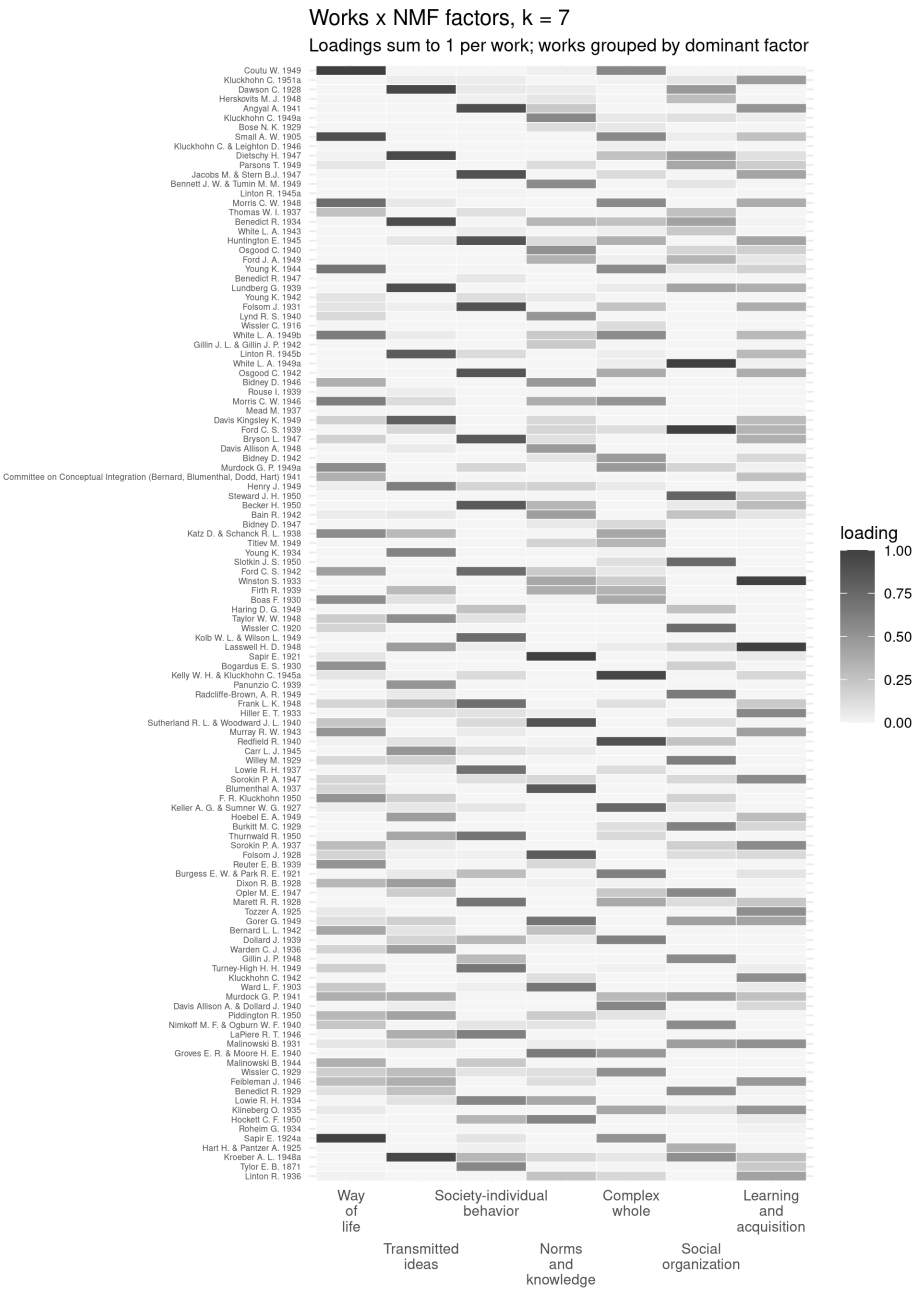


Figure 6: Works × NMF factors at $k = 7$. Each work's loadings sum to one; works are grouped by their dominant factor, ordered within each group by that loading. Factors are labeled by their leading sub-elements (Table 4).



Figure 7: Maximum spanning tree of the works × NMF-factor projection (threshold 0.10), work nodes. Ties count the factors two works share. Color is the leading-eigenvector community on the tree; size is betweenness in the tree.

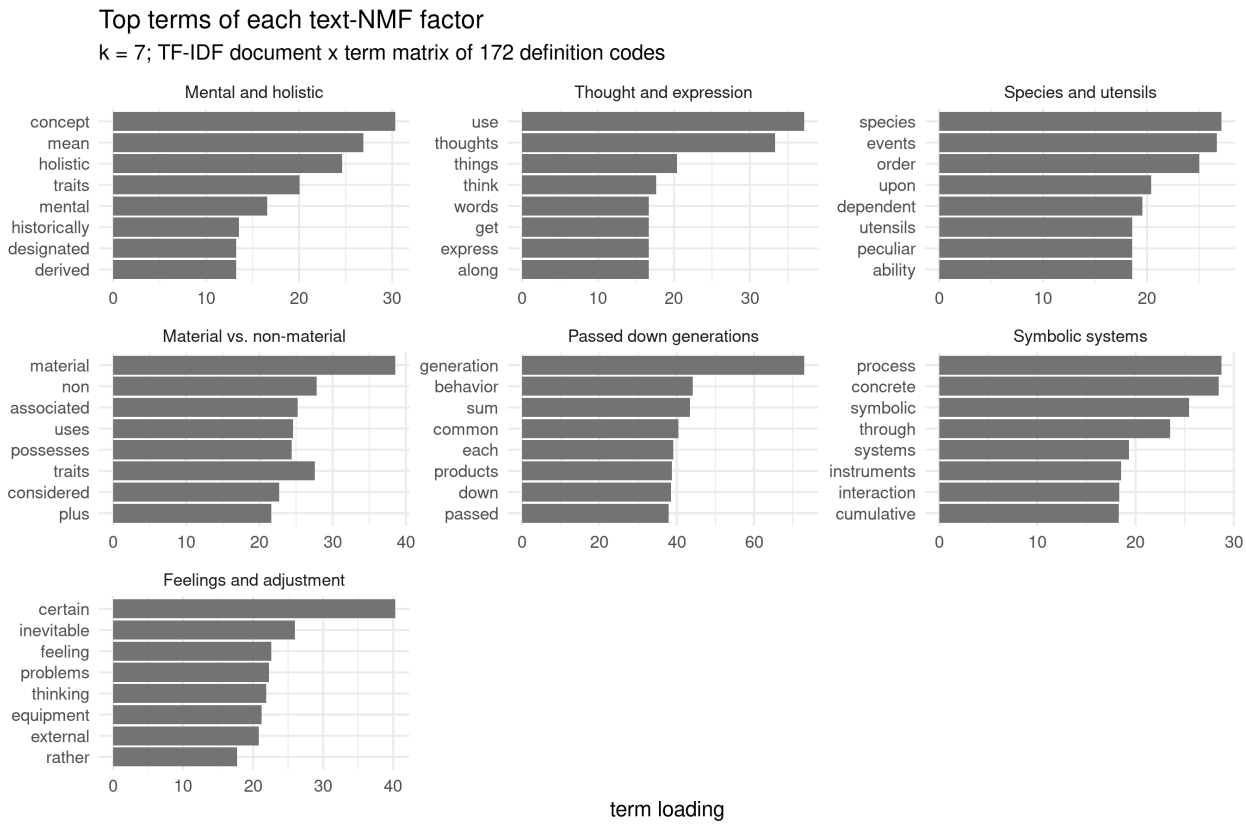


Figure 8: Top terms of each factor of the text NMF at $k = 7$, from the TF–IDF matrix of the 172 definition codes.

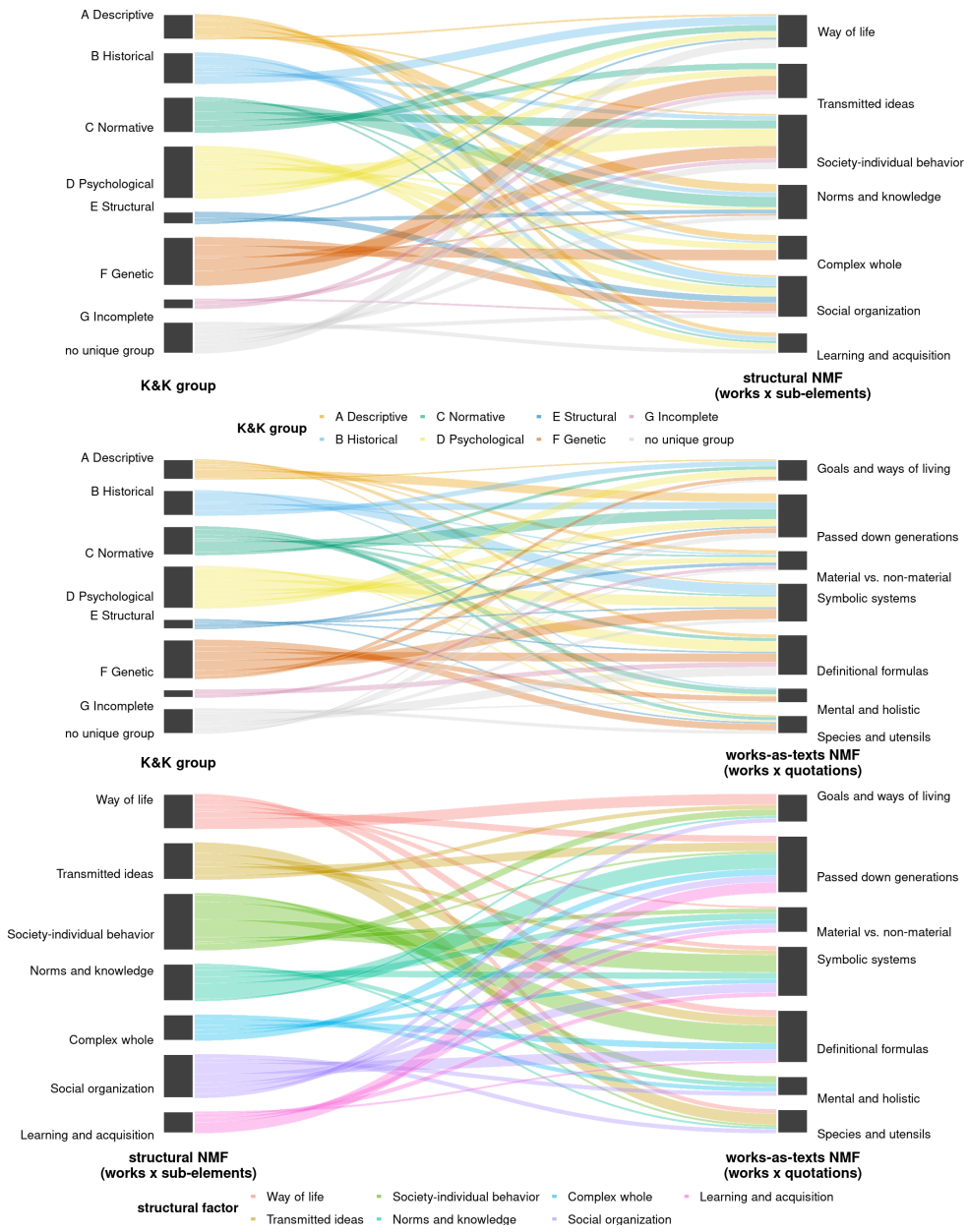


Figure 9: Pairwise agreement of the three classifications of the 118 works of the works 2-core. Top: dominant K&K group against the dominant structural factor. Middle: dominant K&K group against the dominant works-as-texts factor. Bottom: dominant structural factor against the dominant works-as-texts factor. Each ribbon is a flow of works and takes the color of its source node; grey marks the works with no unique K&K group.